

Role Model Reversal

Watching the live telecast of the Nano launch, I was struck by the profundity of the symbolism. Here was India's biggest industrialist launching the world's cheapest car. Now, here's the thing. When he first conceived the idea, it was more idealistic than commercial: that a family of four riding a scooter in the monsoon rain or midsummer heat should have a car they can afford: very altruistic, very Ratan Tata. Now that the economic meltdown has demanded sharp downturns in our lifestyle, the Nano seems like the most brilliant corporate idea since sliced bread. Luck, by chance, as the movie says. Yet, almost every other business activity that the humungous Tata Group is involved in is in trouble and its recent global forays—Corus, Land Rover/Jaguar—hailed as strategic masterstrokes at the time, now look like nightmare business decisions. True, almost every other business group is in the same leaky boat but Ratan Tata is India's leading role model, the poster boy of Corporate India. If he has tripped and stumbled, who else is there to look up to?

The truth is that the speed with which the economic landscape has changed means that the touchstones that defined our existence are no longer valid, and that includes role models. The Ambani brothers, gridlocked in rivalry and petty one-upmanship, have fallen in favour, along with their revenues. The stock market wizards, like the stocks they picked, have also plummeted in our esteem, as have so many of our icons across the board. Satyam's Raju symbolised venality and greed but today, even IT titans like Murthy, Premji, Nilekani and others are diminished by their bottomlines, as are the real estate moguls we envied and admired.

With capitalism out of favour, these are tough times to seek solace and even tougher to find icons we can believe in. Over in America, the dizzying, almost surreal surge of global hope in Barack Obama is fast subsiding. Clearly, we need new role models, but where will they come from? The original phrase was created by an American researcher who hypothesised that individuals compare themselves with reference groups of people who occupy the social role to which the individual aspires. That was fine when the economy was booming and billionaires were sprouting like, well, sprouts. What price role models now?



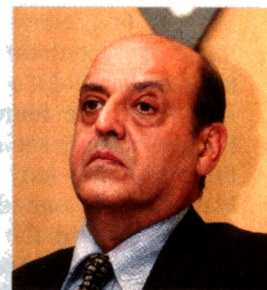
I have a theory. Just as yesterday's role models have diminished, so have our expectations. The economic downturn will require role models who are not glitzy money-makers but those who are socially responsible and contribute to society and nation-building, the ones who leave a positive mark on the world. They could well be environmentalists, educationists, doctors, social activists and the like, smaller in financial worth but bigger in stature and sensibilities. That's not a bad role reversal.



THE ECONOMIC DOWNTURN DEMANDS NEW ROLE MODELS, NOT GLITZY MONEY-MAKERS BUT ONES WHO MAKE A VISIBLE SOCIAL CONTRIBUTION.

SIGNPOSTS

DISMISSED: By the Supreme Court, a petition challenging the continuance of **Navin Chawla** as the election commissioner in view



of CEC N. Gopalswami's recommendation for his removal.

SENTENCED: **Kompamma** alias 'Cyanide Mallika', 44, India's first woman serial killer, to death by a Tumkur court. She poisoned five women to death in the past eight years before robbing them.

BANNED: By the Goa Government, the **Sri Rama Sene**, after its chief **Pramod Muthalik** said that the state was the root cause of pub culture in the country. He was earlier banned from entering Mangalore.

APPOINTED: **Air Marshal Pradeep Malik** as the next chief of air staff. He will succeed Air Chief Marshal **Fali Homi Major** on May 31.

